

In March 2012, Google rebranded the Android Market as the Google Play Store, and expanded its offering from providing just Android apps to a library of digital media content, including books, movies and music, merging its Google Music brand under the Google Play Store as well.

Openness of the Android platform

The openness of Android is one of its most important strongpoints. Giving away the source code for free opens up nearly limitless potential for customization and hacking, and the strong and ever growing community behind Android has done just that. One of the best examples of this are the aftermarket firmware or Custom ROMs available for many popular Android devices. While a ROM traditionally refers to ‘Read Only Memory’, the Android community changed it to mean a modified image of the operating system that can be installed (or flashed) on a phone to increase its capabilities. ROMs can be engineered to fix bugs with the original firmware, make devices faster and more capable or to provide more frequent and timely updates to higher versions of Android. Many custom ROMs such as the popular, community supported Cyanogenmod aim to introduce newer features onto older and outdated devices, while others such as MIUI try to improve the aesthetic appeal of the Android experience. The ‘stock’ ROM or the OS that the device ships with may contain unnecessary and bloated applications or undesirable modifications to the Android system forced by the OEM (collectively called crapware or bloatware). Custom ROMs can help in getting rid of such nuisances and deliver a pure Google experience, unhindered by the manufacturers attempt to ‘differentiate’ the device from others in the market.

Another popular technique is to ‘root’ the device, which is Android speak for gaining administrative access to a system’s protected files. Rooting is a popular procedure carried out by many users to extend the capabilities of the device and enable one to take full advantage of the hardware and the software on an Android phone. Once rooted, users are able to use apps that can overclock or underclock a phone’s CPU, use the phone as a wireless hotspot, backup the system securely or remove bloatware. Android’s strong community support ensures that even those users who aren’t technically inclined are able to take advantage of their devices.

While Android’s strength lies in its massive community and developer base thanks to its openness, this is ironically its biggest weakness. The open nature of the platform requires users to be able to install third-party applications easily, but this feature has also contributed to piracy among Android